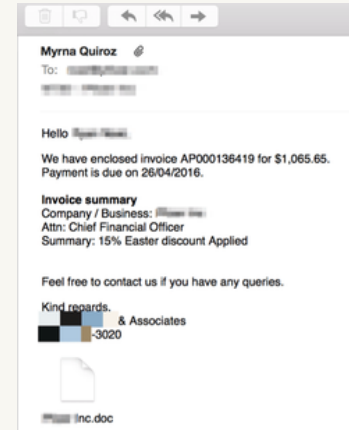


PHISHING AWARENESS TRAINING

CodeAlpha Cyber Security Internship — Task 2
Student Name: Kachroud Maroua

What Is Phishing?

- Phishing is a form of social engineering designed to trick people into revealing information, clicking harmful links, or opening malicious files.
- Attackers often impersonate trusted organizations, colleagues, services, or people.
- Common goals include stealing credentials, financial information, or gaining access to systems.



Why Does Phishing Work?

- Urgency: "Act now" messages reduce the time people spend checking details.
- Authority: attackers may impersonate banks, managers, IT teams, or government services.
- Fear or curiosity: warnings about account closure, invoices, security alerts, or unusual activity.
- Trust: attackers use information found online to make messages look personal and believable.

Common Types of Phishing

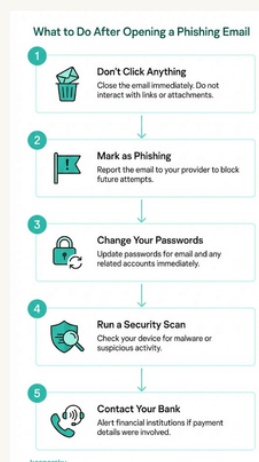
- Spear phishing — targeted messages designed for a specific person or organization.
- Whaling — attacks targeting high-value or senior individuals.
- Smishing — phishing delivered through SMS or messaging apps.



- Vishing — phishing through voice calls or conversations.
- Business Email Compromise (BEC) — impersonation or account compromise used to request money or sensitive actions.

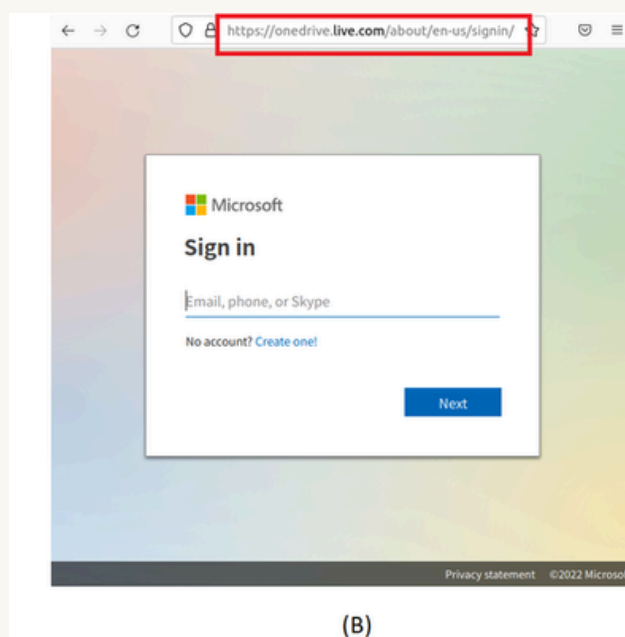
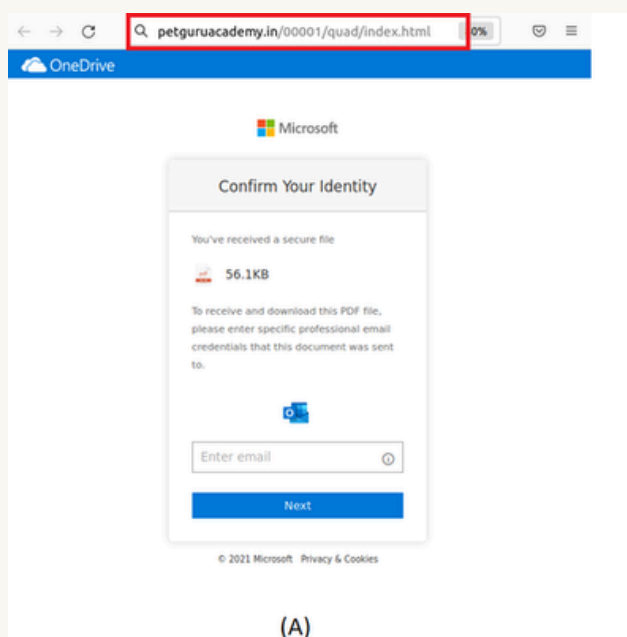
How to Spot a Phishing Email

- Check the sender address carefully ; look for look-alike domains or unexpected addresses.
- Be suspicious of urgent requests for passwords, payments, codes, or sensitive information.
- Hover over links and verify the real destination before clicking.
- Watch for unexpected attachments, spelling/layout problems, generic greetings, or unusual requests.
- Verify important requests through a separate, trusted communication channel



Fake Websites & Login Pages

- A fake site may copy the logo, colors, wording, and layout of a legitimate service.
- HTTPS alone does not prove that a website is legitimate.
- Check the domain name carefully and avoid entering credentials through links in unexpected messages.
- When possible, open the service through a saved bookmark or type the known address yourself.



Social Engineering Tactics

- Pretexting: creating a believable story or identity to obtain information.
- Impersonation: pretending to be a manager, coworker, bank, delivery service, or support agent.
- Baiting: offering something attractive to encourage an unsafe action.
- Quid pro quo: promising a benefit or service in exchange for information or access.
- Tailoring: using public information to make the message more convincing.

Real-World Example: Twitter, 2020

- In July 2020, attackers used social engineering to obtain access to administrative tools used by Twitter.
- The compromised access was then used to take control of accounts and support a fraud scheme.
- Lesson: even well-known organizations can be affected when attackers successfully manipulate people.
- Defense: verify unusual requests, protect privileged access, and use strong authentication and security awareness training.

Best Practices:

Before You Click

- STOP — do not react immediately to pressure or urgency.
- CHECK — inspect the sender, domain, link destination, attachment, and context.
- VERIFY — contact the person or organization using a trusted channel.
- PROTECT — use strong unique passwords and enable MFA.
- REPORT — use your organization's reporting process for suspicious messages.

If You Clicked a Phishing Link

- Do not continue entering information or interacting with the page.
- If you entered a password, change it immediately from a trusted device and review other sessions.
- If MFA or recovery information may be exposed, review account security settings.
- Report the incident to the appropriate security/support team.
- If financial information was exposed, contact the relevant financial institution promptly.

Key Takeaways

- Phishing attacks target people as well as technology.
- Do not trust a message just because it looks professional.
- Inspect sender addresses, links, attachments, and requests.
- Use strong unique passwords and MFA, preferably phishing-resistant methods when available.
- Report suspicious communications—even when you did not click anything.

References

- CISA ; Phishing guidance and phishing awareness resources.
- CISA ; More than a Password / MFA guidance.
- U.S. Department of Justice — 2020 Twitter account compromise case.

Phishing Awareness Quiz

Question 1

You receive an urgent email saying your account will be closed in 10 minutes unless you click a link:

- A. Click immediately
- B. Verify the request through the official service
- C. Reply with your password

Answer: B

Question 2

The visible link says `company.com`, but hovering over it shows a different domain:

- A. Click it
- B. Ignore it and verify independently
- C. Forward it to colleagues

Answer: B

Question 3

Which is a common phishing indicator?

- A. Unexpected urgency
- B. A trusted bookmark you opened yourself
- C. A request you independently confirmed

Answer: A

Question 4

Which action is safest when an email requests sensitive information?

- A. Reply to the email
- B. Use a trusted communication channel to verify the request
- C. Send the information quickly

Answer: B

Question 5

What should you do after entering a password on a suspected phishing page?

- A. Ignore it
- B. Change the password from a trusted device and report the incident
- C. Send the password to IT by email

Answer: B

Question 6 — Smishing

You receive an SMS saying: "Your bank account will be suspended today. Verify your account immediately by clicking this link." What should you do?

- A. Click the link immediately
- B. Reply with your banking information
- C. Ignore the message and verify through the bank's official website or app
- D. Forward the SMS to friends

Answer: C

Explanation: The message uses urgency and an unexpected link. The safest approach is to avoid the link and verify independently through a trusted channel.

Question 7 — Malicious Attachment

You receive an unexpected email containing an .exe attachment. What is the safest action?

- A. Open it to see what the file contains
- B. Download it and scan it later
- C. Do not open it and verify the message through a trusted channel
- D. Forward the attachment to a colleague

Answer: C

Explanation: An unexpected executable attachment can be dangerous. It should not be opened; verify the sender and request through a trusted communication channel.

Date: August 2026